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OPENING DAY

Batter up!? Sox could be a hit if they, well, hit.

CINCINNATI — When you cover a popular team for a half century and spend a few days with them at spring training, folks back home in New England regularly ask, “What do you think of the Sox this year?”

I feel strongly both ways.

This weak phrase was a late-20th century ad campaign for Miller Lite Beer (“Tastes great” or “Less Filling?”), and it’s a common

DAN SHAUGHNESSY

Anthony antics

Roman Anthony is the subject of immense, and perhaps unfair, expectations. **C1.**

Sox roster

A few new faces this season. **C5.**

refrain for fence-straddlers and flip-flopping political candidates.

That’s me with the Alex Cora Athletic Club (ACAC) of 2026.

And, like many of you, I have my doubts.

I like ’em because robotic president of baseball ops Craig Breslow did a nifty job assembling what looks like one of the better starting rotations in baseball. In December of ’24, Brez traded four

minor leaguers for the services of a 24-year-old indomitable lefthanded ace, Garrett Crochet. Months later, Breslow extended Crochet’s contract through 2031, then watched him go 18-5 with a 2.59 ERA and 255 strikeouts — good for second in AL Cy Young voting. Last October, Crochet stuffed the Yankees in a locker, beating the Bombers with 11

SHAUGHNESSY, Page C4

‘The folks who are going to thrive are the ones who are able to make adjustments.’

MARK ISSELHARDT, *maple specialist at University of Vermont Extension*



PHOTOS BY DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

STILL THAT SWEET TASTE OF SUCCESS IN VT. WOODS

Technologies, adaptations keep sugarmakers a step ahead of climate change



Top, Jacob Powsner checked on the boiling in the Baird Farm sugarhouse in North Chittenden, Vt. Above, a syrup specialist revealed the difference in maple syrup color grading.

By Kate Selig

GLOBE STAFF

FAIRFIELD, VT. — In faded photographs hung on the sugarhouse wall, a young couple collect sap from galvanized steel buckets while horses pull a sleigh through snow-covered woods — the storybook image of maple sugaring in New England.

While the horses and buckets are long gone, the warm, caramel scent of boiling sap still drifts through the woods here. And the same couple, Tom and Cecile Branon, now gather sap with more advanced tools: miles of plastic tubing, drawn by vacuum pumps from thousands of trees. Machines concentrate it into a frothy, golden liquid before it is boiled, cutting down the time and energy needed to make syrup.

For years, some climate scientists have been warning that warmer weather could disrupt sap flow, triggering a “maple-pocalypse.” But technologies like the ones the Branons use are keeping sugar makers one step ahead. Vermont’s maple production is booming even as other iconic

MAPLE SYRUP, Page A8

Building a political empire behind RFK Jr.

Publisher plays key role in burgeoning MAHA network

By Tal Kopan

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — In the past three years, Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has had a dramatic ascent, rocketing from the contrarian fringe to the center of the American health system and leader of a burgeoning political movement. At every step, he’s been bolstered behind the scenes by a lesser-known name: Tony Lyons.

A longtime publisher and ally of Kennedy’s, Lyons has built a sprawling political operation to promote Kenne-

dy and his “Make America Healthy Again” brand, a multimillion-dollar endeavor that spans multiple nonprofits, businesses, and a political action committee — one could call it “MAHA Inc.” Under the MAHA banner, Lyons hosts administration officials as he plays emcee on weekly activist organizing calls, holds glitzy cocktail parties at an exclusive D.C. club, and convenes events around the country.

Since his campaign, the MAHA Inc. network has amplified Kennedy’s message and ideas, celebrating Kennedy’s overhaul of the nation’s vaccine system and efforts to revamp its food supply. Increasingly, the network is also cheerleading for President Trump, even as other prominent MAHA activ-

LYONS, Page A6

Stymied, GOP tries audible on shutdown

Seeks to unlink Trump’s bid on election overhaul from bill to fund DHS

By Jim Puzzanghera

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — With airport security lines growing long and time running short before a scheduled congressional recess next week, senators have been scrambling to find a way to end a nearly six-week partial government shutdown of the Department of Homeland Security.

But the difficult task of striking a bipartisan deal for the department, which includes the vital Transportation Security Administration and the polarizing Immigration and Customs Enforcement agency, got even more complicated when President Trump threw a wrench into the process. He’s demanding that any funding agreement also include a controversial Republican election overhaul bill called the SAVE America Act.

Democrats are dead-set against the election legislation, which they said would disenfranchise millions of voters, and a threatened filibuster from them dooms it in the Senate. And Senate Republicans aren’t in lockstep on it either. So,

SHUTDOWN, Page A7

TRACY KIDDER 1945-2026

His books delved deep into human frailty, feats

By Bryan Marquard

GLOBE STAFF

In any setting, and there were many during 50 years of book-length journalism, Tracy Kidder illuminated the human condition with deft phrases and elegant details.

At a nursing home near where he lived in Western Massachusetts, an elderly woman walked with a “hybrid gait of daintiness, frailty, and vigor.” In a suburban Boston computer firm that was a haven for odd metaphors, an executive spoke of “flying upside down. It seemed to mean taking large risks ... a desirable activity — the very stuff of a vigorous life.”

And one evening along a dirt road in Haiti, Mr. Kidder sat beside the passionate cofounder of a nonprofit that provides health care to underdeveloped regions. A murmur of voodoo drums rose from the valley below. “For myself, right now, I like the sound,” he wrote, “like so many hearts beating through a single stethoscope.”

Mr. Kidder, whose best-selling books expanded the depth, range, and popularity of immersive, narrative nonfiction, died in Boston Tuesday, just weeks after becoming very ill. He was 80 and had lived in Williamsburg for many years.

His children, Dr. Alice Kidder Bukhman and Nat Kidder, told The New York Times Mr. Kidder died of lung cancer, and was at

KIDDER, Page A9



JOHN BOHN/GLOBE STAFF FILE 1999

Mr. Kidder earned a Pulitzer for “The Soul of a New Machine.”



Plops into place

Thursday: Soft rain, breezy. High 61-66, low 42-47.

Friday: Cooler, rain early. High 46-51, low 25-30.

Sunrise: 6:37. Sunset: 7:03.

Weather and comics, **D5-6.**

Obituaries, **C10-11.**

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Iran rejected an American plan to pause the war in the Middle East and launched more attacks. **A4.**

The state set up new rules in the rebidding process for the project to upgrade highway service plazas,. **D1.**

The Wu administration is set to finalize cost-cutting plans to limit coverage of GLP-1 weight loss drugs and other medications for city employees and retirees. **B1.**

In a potentially landmark verdict, a jury determined Meta and YouTube harmed a young user with design features that were addictive. **A2.**

The Celtics raced to a 119-109 victory over Oklahoma City, ending the defending champ’s 12-game win streak. **C1.**